prosecution. On 27 June, the state government withdrew the consent given to the CBI to pursue the case.

While the drama of desperation was unfolding in Kerala, I was reinstated at the ISRO headquarters in Bangalore, with effect from 1 July 1996. As I entered ISRO chairman Kasturirangan's room, he stood up to receive me.

'You've been through hell, Mr Nambi,' he said.

I stood still, not showing my anger at this man and the organisation, which made no effort to tell the world the past twenty months that its scientists were clean and the allegations of smuggling out rocket secrets were laughable, if not despicable.

'You have a lot more to contribute,' Kasturirangan continued.

'I've nothing more to contribute,' I said. 'I've got more than enough for all the contribution I have made.'

He mouthed some kind words which both of us knew were hollow. About ten minutes later, I moved to my new office in the ISRO headquarters. Colleagues streamed in, many telling me in hushed tones that it was disappointing how the organisation did not stand by me in testing times. I listened to these formalities with a sense of cultivated equanimity.

The board outside my office room read 'Director, Advanced Technology & Planning'. I got down to planning my legal battle with the Government of Kerala and its minions in khaki.

The Malayalam media, which has been on an overdrive, paused and reflected. But still some of those, who were carried away from the initial days of misreporting on the case and did not bother to check the basic flaws in the allegations, fell silent. The English newspapers, which had refused to buy the spy theory right from the beginning, stood vindicated. Television channels, which lived only in the present, were just happy with the sound bytes.

Now I was mobbed by television channels. In one of the interviews to *Asianet*, I said the government's order for reinvestigation would not stand legal scrutiny. Instead, I said, it should have gone for further investigation.